

Credit Bureau Implementation

Costs, Compliance, Feasibility & Action Plan

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Prepared for	juskel leadership, product, engineering, and compliance
Companion doc	Commercial Credit & Banking Intelligence — Tech Lead Research Report
Basis	Public vendor/industry data + juskel MVP budget constraints (£5–15/mo infra is separate from bureau fees)

Realistic headline: Implementing **production credit bureau enrichment** for juskel is feasible, but it is **not a £500 side project**. A honest **Year 1 budget** for a regulated, consent-gated bureau integration starts around **£8,000–£15,000** on the **lean path** (Creditsafe + legal + engineering), or **£40,000–£80,000+** on the **enterprise path** (Experian/Equifax + FCA/CIGB depth). **Timeline: 3–4 months minimum** on the lean path; **6–9 months** if FCA authorisation and reciprocity reporting are required.

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1. Executive decision summary

juskel is **not a lender today**. The Financial Profile spec wants **Commercial Credit Data Enrichment** to supplement Open Banking — showing SMEs a consolidated view of borrowing/commitments and enriching Banking Intelligence (BIS) **without** juskel becoming a credit reference agency.

This document answers three practical questions:

Question	Short answer
Can we afford it?	Yes on a lean path (~£8–15k Year 1) if pulls are consent-gated and volume is controlled. No if we treat it like free API data at scale.
Are we allowed to?	Maybe — depends on FCA role, permissible purpose, and whether we access CCDS reciprocal data. Legal sign-off required before first production pull.
Will it work for average SMEs?	Partially — bureau files are often thin for sole traders and new companies; product must treat gaps as normal.

Recommendation: Pursue **Path B (Creditsafe lean integration)** in parallel with **Path A (no bureau MVP)**. Do **not** commit to **Path C (Experian/Equifax enterprise)** until legal confirms eligibility and a lender/partner funds the cost — or juskel obtains FCA credit broking/CIS authorisation.

2. Three implementation paths (with costs)

All figures are **planning estimates** in GBP, excluding VAT. Vendor quotes may differ. Assumes UK Ltd-focused SME onboarding.

Path A — No bureau (MVP baseline)

What you get: Manual financial baseline + QuickBooks metrics + TrueLayer Open Banking + banking/borrowing **self-attestation** (no bureau pull).

Cost item	Year 1 estimate	Notes
Credit bureau fees	£0	None
Legal / compliance review	£2,000 – £5,000	One-off: GDPR consent copy, onboarding terms, OB consent
External engineering	£0 (internal)	~2–3 person-weeks internal
TrueLayer (existing)	£500 – £2,000/yr	Volume-dependent SaaS — separate from Azure infra
Path A total (Year 1)	£2,500 – £7,000	Excludes internal salary

Timeline	Milestone
Weeks 1–4	Banking metrics entity, multi-bank UX, completeness attestation
Weeks 5–8	Provenance/confidence flags, align manual baseline to spec
Week 8	MVP Financial Profile shippable without bureau

Feasibility: High — no CRA contract, no reciprocity.

Path B — Lean bureau (Creditsafe Connect) — recommended probe

What you get: SME-consented **UK company credit report** + CCDS finance agreement slice where available; reconciliation UI (corroborated / missing / discrepancy); **no CRA score displayed**.

Cost item	Year 1 estimate	Notes
Creditsafe subscription	£1,200 – £3,500/yr	Tier depends on report credits bundled
Connect API integration fee	£800 – £1,200/yr	Third-party integrators cite ~€1,000; confirm with Creditsafe
Per-report credits (variable)	£3 – £12 per pull	Planning midpoint ~£6/report
Legal / compliance	£3,000 – £8,000	Bureau consent step, permissible purpose memo, DPIA update
CIGB subscription	£0 – £2,500/yr	TBC with legal – may apply if accessing shared performance data
Engineering (internal)	4–6 person-weeks	API client, storage, reconciliation UI contract, e2e
Sandbox / test pulls	£0 – £200	Creditsafe sandbox free; limited live test credits
Path B fixed (Year 1)	£5,000 – £13,200	Before variable pulls
Variable at volume	See Section 3	

Timeline	Milestone
Weeks 1–2	Legal scoping call; Creditsafe sandbox account
Weeks 3–4	Sandbox spike: company lookup + CCDS endpoint for test Ltd
Weeks 5–8	Legal sign-off on consent UX + permissible purpose
Weeks 9–12	Production contract signed; API integrated behind consent gate
Weeks 13–16	Reconciliation UI + e2e tests; soft launch to % of Ltd SMEs
Month 4	Production bureau enrichment live (limited scope)

Feasibility: Medium–High for **Ltd companies**; **Low** for sole traders (thin files).

Reciprocity risk: If Creditsafe classifies juskel as a CCDS finance provider receiving reciprocal pool data, **12-month reporting obligation** may apply — legal must confirm **before contract**.

Path C — Enterprise bureau (Experian or Equifax)

What you get: Full commercial credit API, optional OB+bureau bundle (Equifax OBaaS / Experian Commercial Acumen), decisioning-grade data, CATO/CCDS depth, BIAM enrichment at scale.

Cost item	Year 1 estimate	Notes
Vendor setup / onboarding	£8,000 – £25,000	Integration, IP allowlisting, UAT
Annual platform / minimum commit	£15,000 – £45,000/yr	Enterprise sales; often minimum search commits
Per-search / per-account (variable)	£5 – £25+ per event	Product-dependent
CIGB subscription	£1,500 – £5,000/yr	Typical for data subscribers — confirm with CIGB
FCA authorisation (if required)	£1,500 application + £500–£2k/yr	Credit broking or CIS — 3–6 month process
Legal / compliance programme	£8,000 – £20,000	Ongoing advisory, policies, audits
Reciprocity reporting build	8–12 person-weeks	If CCDS contributor — pipeline + ops
Path C total (Year 1)	£40,000 – £80,000+	Excludes internal salary

Timeline	Milestone
Month 1	Vendor RFP, legal feasibility, FCA strategy decision
Months 2–3	Contract negotiation, sandbox/ UAT access
Months 4–5	Integration + reciprocity reporting (if required)
Month 6–9	Production go-live, monitoring, lender-facing BIS

Feasibility: Medium — eligibility uncertain for non-lender platform; **high cost** for MVP-stage juskel.

3. Year 1 cost model by SME volume

Assumes **Path B (Creditsafe)** with **opt-in bureau step** — not every SME triggers a pull.

SMEs completing bureau step (Year 1)	Variable report cost (@ £6/pull)	Path B Year 1 total (fixed + variable)
100	£600	£5,600 – £13,800
500	£3,000	£8,000 – £16,200
2,000	£12,000	£17,000 – £25,200
10,000	£60,000	£65,000 – £73,200

At **10,000+ pulls/year**, per-report pricing dominates. Negotiate **annual credit bundles** or move cost to **lenders post-match** (commercial model), not juskel infra budget.

Azure infra (£5–15/mo) covers hosting only — **bureau fees are a separate budget line**.

4. Compliance — what applies to juskel

This is not legal advice. Use this as a **briefing for your solicitor/compliance adviser**.

4.1 Regulations and schemes

Framework	Applies when	juskel impact
UK GDPR / Data Protection Act 2018	Any personal or business data processing	Privacy notice, DPIA, consent records, retention
CCDS Regulations 2015	Accessing government-mandated SME credit sharing pool	Reciprocity within 12 months if juskel is a finance provider receiving data
Principles of Reciprocity (CIGB)	Accessing shared credit performance data	Permitted purposes: responsible lending, fraud, debt recovery — not generic analytics
FCA FSMA authorisation	Credit broking, credit information services, certain introductions	TBC — depends whether juskel facilitates credit decisions with bureau data
Consumer Credit Act / CRA 1974	Consumer (director) credit searches	If searching individuals (sole traders, PG) — stricter rules
PSD2 / Open Banking	Already in scope via TrueLayer	Separate consent from bureau step

4.2 What juskel must not do (per spec + regulation)

- Display a bureau **credit score** as if juskel issued it
- Add an 8th BIS dimension that is effectively a CRA score
- Pull bureau data **without** SME consent and documented permissible purpose
- Access CCDS reciprocal pool **without** understanding reciprocity obligations
- Present bureau data as **complete** when coverage is partial (~25% national CCDS consent rate on designated bank accounts)

4.3 Permissible purpose — working positions (confirm with legal)

juskel use case	Likely permissible?	Notes
SME views own company report summary during onboarding	Strongest case	SME-initiated, transparency
juskel enriches internal BIS without showing raw bureau to lenders	Plausible	Still needs purpose documentation
juskel shows bureau-derived flags to lenders on marketplace	Higher bar	Likely CIS or broking authorisation
Hard search affecting company credit file	Avoid for MVP	Soft/report products preferred

5. Compliance action checklist & timeline

#	Action	Owner	Cost est.	When
1	Compliance scoping workshop — define juskel's FCA status and bureau use case	Legal + Product	£500 – £1,500	Week 1
2	Permissible purpose memo — document why each data field is pulled	Legal	£1,500 – £3,000	Weeks 2–3
3	DPIA update — bureau data flows, retention, subprocessors	Legal / DPO	£1,000 – £2,500	Weeks 3–4
4	SME consent copy — separate step for commercial credit (not bundled with OB)	Legal + Product	£800 – £2,000	Weeks 4–5
5	Terms of service update — data sharing, third-party CRAs	Legal	£500 – £1,500	Weeks 5–6
6	CIGB subscriber assessment — required?	Legal	£0 – £500 review	Week 4
7	FCA authorisation decision — proceed, defer, or partner model	Leadership + Legal	£0 (decision)	Week 6
8	Vendor contract review — reciprocity clauses, permitted use, SLAs	Legal	£1,000 – £3,000	Before signature

#	Action	Owner	Cost est.	When
9	Go/no-go gate — no production API key until 1–8 complete	Engineering	£0	Before Week 9

Compliance timeline summary: Allow **6–8 weeks** from kickoff to **safe production bureau pull**, assuming legal resource is available.

6. Feasibility — will it work for our SMEs?

6.1 Expected hit rate (planning assumptions)

SME type	Bureau file useful?	Expected enrichment value
Ltd, 2+ years, B2B credit	60–75%	Facilities, limits, performance flags
Ltd, < 12 months	20–35%	Often thin file
Sole trader / partnership	10–25%	Commercial file weak; consumer leg separate
No prior commercial borrowing	5–15%	“Insufficient coverage” normal
CCDS- enriched slice (all types)	~25% of eligible bank accounts nationally	Government PIR 2024 — consent bottleneck

6.2 Product feasibility rules

1. **Gate bureau step to Ltd + Companies House number** for MVP — reduces wasted pulls.
2. **Charge pulls to opt-in** — “Strengthen my profile with commercial credit data.”
3. **Always show coverage status** — corroborated / additional / discrepancy / insufficient.
4. **Never block onboarding** on empty bureau response.
5. **Cache report 90 days** per application to control cost.

Overall feasibility verdict: Bureau enrichment is **worth doing on Path B** for funding readiness if expectations are set correctly. It is **not feasible** to promise complete borrowing visibility for every average SME.

7. What we need to do — phased action plan

Phase 0 — Decide & de-risk (Weeks 1–6)

Goal: Know if we can legally pull data and which vendor fits budget.

Week	Engineering	Product	Legal	Commercial
1	Read research PDF; spike Creditsafe sandbox signup	Confirm Path A vs B for MVP scope	Scoping call	—
2	Sandbox: authenticate, lookup test Ltd, log response shape	Draft consent UX wireframe	Permissible purpose draft	Email Creditsafe sales
3	Map API fields → juskel reconciliation model	Review hit-rate assumptions	DPIA draft	Email Experian + Equifax (optional)
4	Estimate eng tasks for Path B	Gate rules (Ltd only?)	CIGB assessment	Compare quotes
5	—	Sign-off Path B budget band (£8–15k Y1)	Consent copy v1	Creditsafe proposal
6	Go/no-go meeting		Legal gate document	Contract negotiation start

Phase 0 cost: £2,000 – £6,000 (legal) + internal time.

Phase 1 — Ship MVP without bureau (Weeks 1–8, parallel)

Goal: Spec-aligned Financial Profile without waiting for CRA contract.

Deliverable	Effort
BankingIntegrationMetrics + stop balance→revenue band hack	1.5 weeks
Multi-bank connection + completeness attestation	1.5 weeks
Manual baseline alignment (8 questions or band map)	1 week
Provenance + confidence on GET responses	1 week
Borrowing completeness attestation (manual, no bureau)	0.5 week

Phase 1 incremental cost: £0 bureau (internal engineering only).

Phase 2 — Creditsafe production (Weeks 7–16)

Goal: Consent-gated bureau pull for eligible Ltd SMEs.

Week	Deliverable
7–8	Production API credentials; <code>CommercialCreditSnapshot</code> entity
9–10	Consent middleware + audit log; pull on opt-in only
11–12	Reconciliation service (4 outcomes); API GET fields
13–14	Swagger + <code>ONBOARDING_FRONTEND_API.md</code> ; e2e script
15–16	Soft launch; monitor cost per pull; tune gating

Phase 2 incremental cost: £3,000 – £7,200 fixed + £6 × opt-in pulls.

Phase 3 — Scale or upgrade (Month 6+, optional)

Only if Path B proves value **and** legal confirms Path C eligibility:

- Negotiate Experian Commercial Credit or Equifax EBI/CCDS enterprise tier
- FCA authorisation if introducing to lenders with bureau-enriched BIS
- Reciprocity reporting pipeline if CCDS contributor status triggered
- BIAM dimension weighting from bureau fields in scoring module

Phase 3 cost: See Path C — **£40k–£80k+ Year 1.**

8. Engineering effort & internal cost

Planning rates assume **internal** delivery (no agency). For budgeting internal time at a notional **£500/day** fully loaded:

Phase	Person-weeks	Notional internal value
Phase 0 spike	1 week	£2,500
Phase 1 (no bureau MVP)	3 weeks	£7,500
Phase 2 (Creditsafe)	5 weeks	£12,500
Phase 3 (enterprise)	10+ weeks	£25,000+

Total internal engineering (Path A + B): ~9 person-weeks over 4 months.

9. Vendor cost comparison (realistic ranges)

Vendor	Setup	Annual fixed	Per pull	Sandbox	Best for juskel
Creditsafe Connect	Low	£2–4k	£3–12	Free	Path B — MVP probe
Experian Commercial Credit API	£8–25k	£15–40k	£5–25	Login-gated	Path C — lender-grade
Experian Commercial Acumen	High	£20k+	Bundled	Sales-led	OB+bureau bundle (replaces TrueLayer?)
Equifax OB Commercial + EBI	£5–15k	£12–35k	Bundled	Login-gated	Path C — single vendor OB+bureau
D&B	£5–20k	£10–30k	Variable	Sales-led	Alternative CRA
TransUnion (commercial)	N/A	N/A	N/A	Via reseller	Not primary for commercial CCDS

All vendor figures are estimates until written quotes are received.

10. Risks that change cost or timeline

Risk	Cost impact	Timeline impact
Legal says FCA authorisation required	+£5–15k; +3–6 months	Delays Phase 2 production
CCDS reciprocity triggered	+8–12 eng weeks ongoing ops	+2–3 months
Creditsafe contract minimum above budget	May force defer or Path A only	+4–8 weeks renegotiation
Low opt-in rate (<10% SMEs)	Low variable cost but weak ROI	May question Phase 2 value
High opt-in without caching	Variable cost spike	Need pricing change mid-year
Sole traders expected to use bureau	Wasted pulls	Product fix — Ltd gate

11. Recommended path for juskel

Recommended: Path A now + Path B in parallel

Item	Decision
Now (Weeks 1–8)	Ship Financial Profile MVP without bureau — TrueLayer + QuickBooks + attestations
Parallel (Weeks 1–6)	Legal scoping + Creditsafe sandbox — £2–6k legal
Month 3–4	If legal go: Creditsafe production — £5–13k fixed Year 1 + opt-in pulls
Defer	Experian/Equifax enterprise until funded or FCA path clear
Budget ask (Year 1)	£10,000 – £18,000 all-in for Path A + B (100–500 opt-in SMEs)
Timeline	4 months to bureau live; 2 months to MVP without bureau

What leadership should approve

1. **£2,000 – £6,000** legal budget for Phase 0 compliance (immediate)
2. **£5,000 – £8,000** Creditsafe fixed costs (after legal go, ~Month 2)
3. **£3,000** variable buffer for Year 1 report pulls (500 SMEs × £6)
4. **9 person-weeks** engineering capacity over 4 months (internal)
5. Explicit **no production bureau pull** rule until legal sign-off document exists

12. Sign-off checklist before spending money

Before paying any CRA or signing a bureau contract:

- ☐ Written **permissible purpose** opinion from legal
- ☐ Confirmed whether juskel triggers **CCDS reciprocity**
- ☐ Confirmed whether **CIGB subscription** is required
- ☐ Confirmed whether **FCA authorisation** is required for chosen UX
- ☐ SME **consent screen** approved by legal (separate from OB)
- ☐ **DPIA** updated with CRA subprocessor
- ☐ Written **vendor quote** with per-pull pricing and minimum commit

- ☐ Product rule: **Ltd-only gate** (or documented exception)
 - ☐ Engineering: **cache + audit log** design approved
 - ☐ Budget owner sign-off on **Year 1 £10–18k band**
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Cost figures are estimates for budgeting only, not vendor quotes or legal advice. Update decision log after Creditsafe / legal engagements.